[Afghanistan] but didn't know who to talk to. In that situation, the US pushed Karzai and gave India a legitimate face to talk to'.[154] But Rabbani's marginalisation at Bonn (he wanted to continue as president and consolidate his power base) strained India's UF-centric approach, and eventually made it redundant as the UF disintegrated under the weight of its own contradictions. Principally, thus, India viewed its support to the Rabbani government till 2001 as legitimate engagement with an internationally recognised government. In practice, however, it was anti-Pakistan proxy calculus at its extreme that only limited India's influence at Bonn.

The conference also showed that both India and the UN had lost faith in each other's capability to broker peace in Afghanistan. According to Abdullah, current Chief Executive of Afghanistan, Brahimi actively discouraged the Afghan government from getting too close to India.[155] The reason was always related to Pakistan's sensitivity towards Indian involvement. Even though Washington and many other countries eventually came to terms with the necessity of India's presence in Afghanistan, the UN remained wary. Finally, even if India had decided to boycott the conference, it would not have altered the outcome. X accepts that the US would have ensured a deal that favoured them with or without India's help. In fact, X had been reluctant to visit Bonn in the first place knowing the limits of India's influence, but was pushed by Brajesh Mishra for the R&AW had to have some presence on the ground in Bonn. As X put it, 'we eased the way for the US and the UN at Bonn. And Dobbins does not give us credit for that. But it's true that we were not the most important player in town those days'.[156]

What impact did the Bonn conference have on India's approach towards Afghanistan in the subsequent months? First, it gave fresh impetus to the debate between the partisans and the conciliators. Instead of debating whether to engage or not with the Taliban (at least not yet), the dilemma was whether to balance relations between different Afghan factions within and outside the new government, and if yes, then how. Though the 9/11 attacks and Operation Parakram helped in consolidating the partisan's coercive strategy, Washington's alliance with Pakistan and support for Karzai complicated its implementation. Dissolution of the UF added to the partisan's woes, making them miss Massoud's